

also creates a big problem in terms of fair pricing for a consumer.

As consumers, when we buy a device, and break a part of it, repairing the device should certainly not cost as much as a brand new device does. What's happening now is that brands (Apple is a prime example here of a brand that many complain about) dictate their own repair prices, and offer up a quote to a consumer that is often more than what they paid for the device to begin with, citing massive problems that seem hard to fix. When these consumers head back to third party repair shops, who are very often not Apple certified, they find out that the problem was minimal, and sometimes terribly simple such as a cable coming loose!

ENVIRONMENT

Consumers often damage their devices, with liquids being the most common form of damage... water causes corrosion to occur and even sometimes shorts out components, ruining them! That's the worst case scenario though, because often the device itself might stop working, but a skilled technician will quickly and deftly remove capacitors from a donor board and install them onto your board, and voila, job done. The

problem is that brands like Apple, Microsoft, Google and even Facebook, actively discourage third party repair.

Apple, for instance, has been known to use loopholes in US law to seize shipments of spare parts coming from China to the US, because the product contains their logo on it. These spare parts are often taken out of junked phones and laptops that were deemed to be damaged beyond repair, and shipped off to some third world country or the other to be recycled. The recycling company has then extracted these boards, batteries or other parts from these junk devices, and sells them to the highest bidder. This prevents a large chunk of them going into a landfill somewhere and poisoning the land.

One aspect of the right to repair is a no-brainer, which is that repairing a device is always going to be more environmentally friendly than buying a new one. And encouraging a second-hand market to thrive by allowing repairs to be cheaply available, locally, to most people on earth would go a long way in helping people feel comfortable buying a second hand device.

For all their claims of being concerned about the environment, all technology brands are responsible for contributing to the degradation of our

environment, and for not mitigating their effects by at least allowing their devices to be used long term by multiple different owners.

We consumers too, have to hold up our hands and accept that we are just as responsible for harming the environment as the brands. There are still gadget manufacturers who provide parts and repair manuals and schematics for their products, and even make sure that spares are available. We owe it to the environment to do our research and choose brands that put the environment first when making their devices. We will keep you updated about devices and brands that are embracing the right to repair movement, and we're currently in the process of figuring out how to rank brands based on their repairability. For now, we have iFixit's repairability score, which currently looks at how a device is put together. We want to aim higher and see if we can factor in more than just that into perhaps a "green score" for brands and devices. Do you think it would be worth it for us to put in the hard work of collecting data and trying to award brands with such a score? Would you base your buying decisions on how green (or not) a brand is, or how repairable a product is? 

LEGISLATION

WHAT WOULD RIGHT TO REPAIR MEAN FOR US

Honestly, we feel that India is perfectly poised to join the leaders of the right to repair fight. We have one of the most promising markets in the world, and every technology brand is desperate to get to the next billion users who will become tech savvy soon. India is the majority contribution to the next

billion users to come online, and they're going to need devices to use to get online. The right legislation could force companies that want to do business in a market as big as ours, to provide adequate spares and repair documentation for their products.

India has always been a place where nothing really goes to waste anyway, with people finding fortunes in other

people's waste. This especially holds true for e-waste, but a lot of it is being wasted (pun not intended). The Central Pollution Control Board reported that India was only recycling a mere 10 per cent of e-waste that was being generated in 2019 (<https://dgit.in/3lqRlRL>). After the chaos of the pandemic, this figure might be far worse for 2020 and 2021. This is obviously not good